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**WHAT IS
DEMOCRACY?
WHY DEMOCRACY?**

Ch 1 | Class 9 S.St. (Civics)

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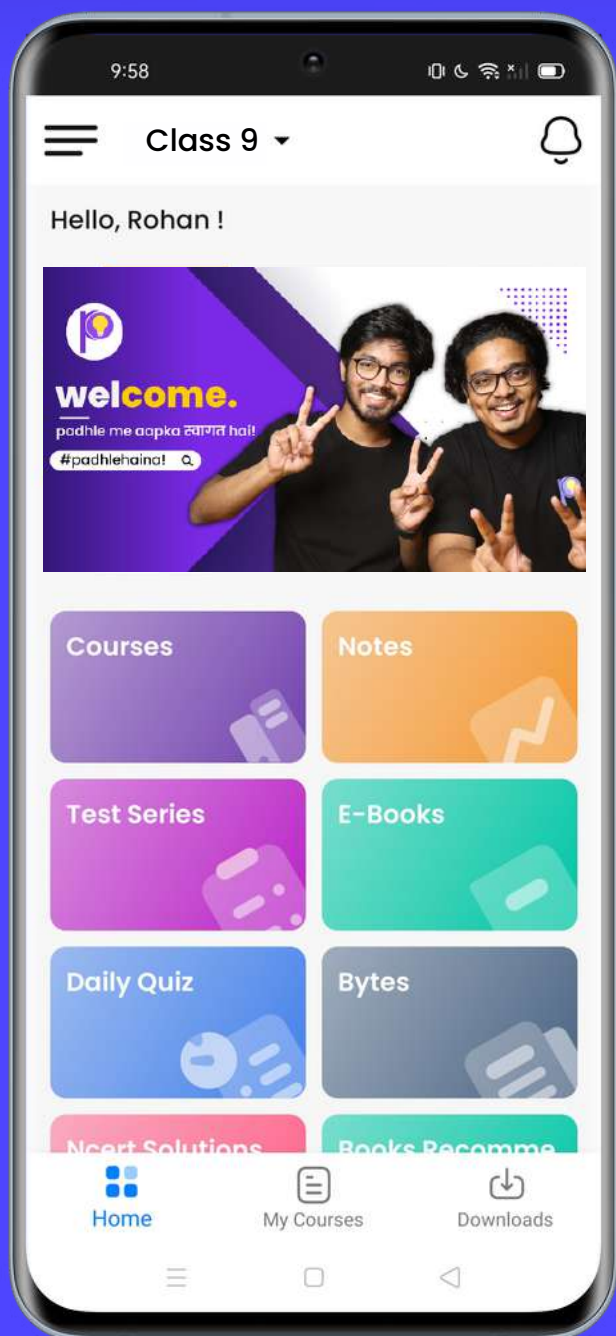
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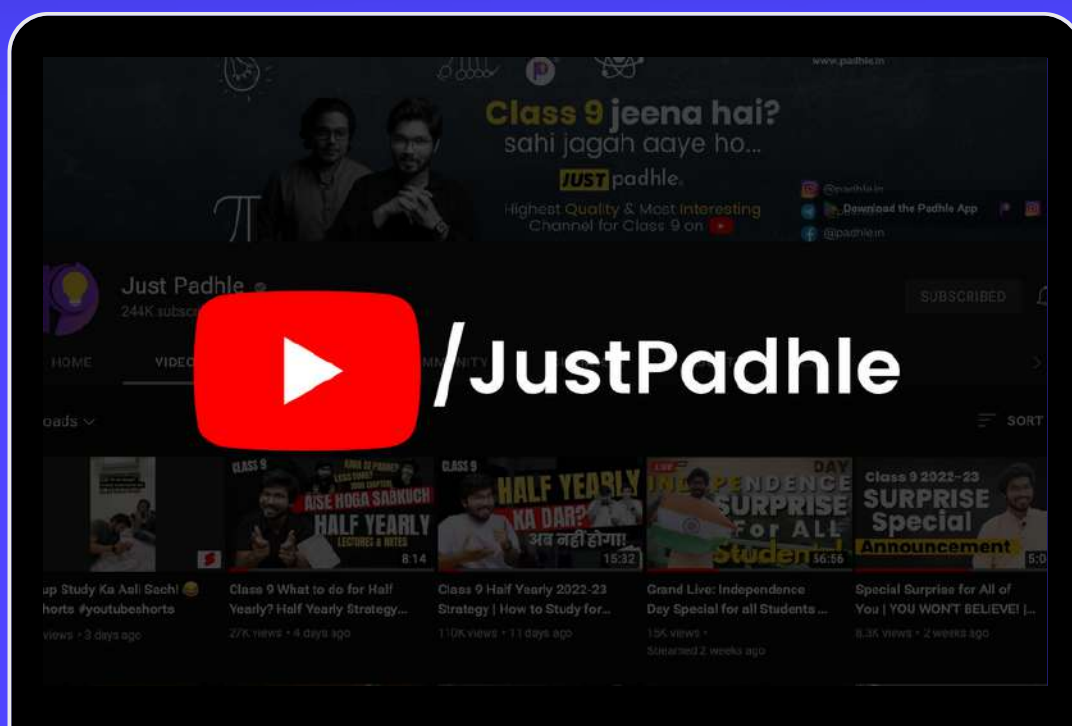
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WHAT IS DEMOCRACY? WHY IS DEMOCRACY?

* Overview :

- This chapter builds on a simple definition of democracy.
- Step by step, we work out the meaning of the terms involved in this definition.
- The aim here is to understand clearly the bare minimum features of a democratic form of government.
- After going through this chapter we should be able to distinguish a democratic form of government from a non-democratic government.

What is Democracy?

- We could thus start with a simple definition :

DEMOCRACY IS A FORM OF GOVERNMENT IN WHICH THE RULES ARE ELECTED BY THE PEOPLE

- This definition allows us to separate democracy from forms of government that are clearly not democratic.

- The army rulers of Myanmar are not elected by the people.

- Dictators like Pinochet (Chile) are not elected by the people.

- This also applies to monarchies.

* This simple definition is not adequate.

- It reminds us that democracy is people's rule.
- But if we use this definition in an unthinking manner, we would end up calling almost every government that holds an election a democracy.

That would be very misleading because -
Every government in contemporary world wants to be called a democracy, even if it is not so.

That is why we need to carefully distinguish between a government that is a democracy and one that pretends to be one.

We can do so by understanding each word in this definition carefully and specially out the features of a democratic government

* Features of Democracy

◇ We have started with a simple definition that democracy is a form of government in which the rulers are elected by the people.

◇ This raises many questions :

▷ Who are the rulers in this definition ?

→ Which officials must be elected for any government to be called a democracy?

→ Which decisions may be taken by non-elected officials in a democracy?

▷ What kind of election constitutes a democratic election ?

→ What conditions must be fulfilled for an election to be considered democratic ?

► Who are the people who can elect the rulers or get elected as rulers?

- Should this include every citizen on an equal basis?

- Can a democracy deny some citizens this rights?

► Finally, what kind of a form of government is democracy?

- Can elected rulers do whatever they want in a democracy?

- Or must a democratic government function with some limits?

- Is it necessary for a democracy to respect some rights of the citizens?

Let us consider each of these questions with the help of some examples

* Major Decisions by Elected Leaders

Case of Pakistan

► In Pakistan, General Pervez Musharraf led a military coup in October 1999.

► He overthrew a democratically elected government and declared himself the 'Chief Executive' of the country.

► Later he changed his designation to President and in 2002 held a referendum in the country that granted him a five year extension.

► Pakistani media, human rights organisations and democracy activists said that the referendum was based on malpractices and fraud.

► In August 2002 he issued a 'Legal Framework Order' that amended the Constitution of Pakistan.

► According to this Order, the President can dismiss the national and provincial assemblies.

► The work of the civilian cabinet is supervised by a National Security Council which is dominated by military officers.

- ▶ After passing this law, elections were held to the national and provincial assemblies.
- ▶ So Pakistan has had elections, elected representatives have some powers.
- ▶ But the final powers rest with military officers and General Musharraf himself.
- ✦ Clearly, there are many reasons why Pakistan under General Musharraf should not be called a democracy.

Q. Can we say that the rulers are elected by the people in Pakistan?

Not quite

- People may have elected their representatives to the national and provincial assemblies but those elected representatives are not really the rulers.
- They cannot take the final decision.
- This happens in many dictatorships and monarchies.
- They formally have an elected parliament and government but the real power is with those who are not elected.

This cannot be called people's rule

1.

In a democracy the final decision making power must rest with those elected by the people.

* Free And Fair Electoral Competition

* Case of China

- In China, elections are regularly held after every five years for electing the country's parliament, called National People's Congress.
- The National People's Congress has the power to appoint the President of the country.
- It has nearly 3,000 members elected from all over China.
 - Some members are elected by the army.

- Before contesting elections, a candidate needs the approval of the Chinese Communist Party.
- Only those who are members of the Chinese Communist Party or eight smaller parties allied to it were allowed to contest elections held in 2002-03.
- The government is always formed by the Communist Party

* Case of Mexico

- Mexico holds elections after every six years to elect its President.
- The country has never been under a military or dictator's rule.
- But until 2000 every election was won by a party called PRI (Institutional Revolutionary Party).
- Opposition parties did contest elections, but never managed to win.
- The PRI was known to use many dirty tricks to win elections.
- All those who were employed in government offices had to vote for the PRI.
- Media largely ignored the activities of opposition political parties except to criticise them.
- Sometimes the polling booths were shifted from one place to another in the last minute, which made it difficult for people to cast their votes.
- The PRI spent a large sum of money in the campaign for its candidates.

◇ Should we consider the elections described above as examples of people electing their rulers?

In China the elections do not offer the people any serious choice.

- They have to choose the ruling party and the candidates approved by it.

In the Mexican example, people seemed to really have a choice but in practice they had no choice.

- There was no way the ruling party could be defeated, even if people were against it.

♦ The elections must offer a real choice between political alternatives.

②.

A democracy must be based on a free and fair election where those currently in power have a fair chance of losing

ONE PERSON, ONE VOTE, ONE VALUE

→ There are many instances of denial of equal right to vote.

- In Saudi Arabia women do not have the right to vote.
- Estonia has made its citizenship rules in such a way that people belonging to Russian minority find it difficult to get the right to vote.
- In Fiji, the electoral system is such that the vote of an indigenous Fijian has more value than that of an Indian-Fijian.

③.

In a democracy, each adult citizen must have one vote and each vote must have one value.

RULE OF LAW AND RESPECT FOR RIGHTS

* Case of Zimbabwe

- Zimbabwe attained independence from White minority rule in 1980.
- Since, then the country has been ruled by ZANU-PF, the party that led the freedom struggle.
- Its leader, Robert Mugabe, has been ruling the country since independence.
- Elections have been held regularly and always won by ZANU-PF.
- President Mugabe is popular but also uses unfair practices in elections.
- Over the years his government has changed the constitution several times to increase the powers of the President and make him less accountable.

- Opposition party workers are harassed and their meeting disrupted.
- Public protests and demonstrations against the government are declared illegal.
- There is a law that limits the right to criticise the President.
- Television and radio are controlled by the government and give only the ruling party's version.
- There are independent newspapers but the government harasses those journalists who go against it.
- The government has ignored some court judgements that went against it and has pressurised judges.

- ✧ The example of Zimbabwe shows that popular approval of the rulers is necessary in a democracy, but it is not sufficient.
- ✧ Popular government can be undemocratic.
- ✧ Popular leaders can be autocratic.

There should be sufficient room for normal political activity, including political opposition, in the period before elections.

This requires that the state should respect some basic rights of the citizen.

- Everyone should be equal in the eyes of law.
- These rights must be protected by an independent judiciary whose orders are obeyed by everyone.
- ▶ Similarly, there are some conditions that apply to the way a government is run after the elections :
 - A democratic government cannot do whatever it likes, simply because it has won an election.
 - It has to respect some basic rules.
 - In particular it has to respect some guarantees to the minorities.
 - Every major decision has to go through a series of consultations.

→ Every office bearer has certain rights and responsibilities assigned by the constitution and the law.

④.

A democratic government rules within limits set by constitutional law and citizens' right.

SUMMARY DEFINITION

► We started with a simple definition that :

Democracy is a form of government in which the rulers are elected by the people.

- We found that this definition was not adequate unless we explained some of the key words used in it.
- Through a series of examples we worked out four features of democracy as a form of government.

► Accordingly, democracy is a form of government in which :

- Rulers elected by the people take all the major decisions.
- Elections offer a choice and fair opportunity to the people to change the current rulers.
- This choice and opportunity is available to all the people on an equal basis.
- The exercise of this choice leads to a government limited by basic rules of the constitution and citizens' rights.

Why Democracy?

Arguments against Democracy

- Leaders keep changing in a democracy.
- This leads to instability.

- Democracy is all about political competition and power play.
 - There is no scope for mortality.
- So many people have to be consulted in a democracy that it leads to delays.
- Elected leaders do not know the best interest of the people.
 - It leads to bad decisions.
- Democracy leads to corruption for it is based on electoral competition.
- Ordinary people don't know what is good for them; should not decide anything.
- Clearly, democracy is not a magical solution for all the problems.
- It has not ended poverty in our country and in other parts of the world.
- Democracy as a form of government only ensure that people take their own decisions.
 - This does not guarantee that their decisions will be good.
- People can make mistakes.
 - Involving the people in these decisions does lead to delays in decision making.
- It is also true that democracy leads to frequent changes in leadership.
 - Sometimes this can set back big decisions and affect the government's efficiency.
- These arguments show that democracy of the kind we see may not be the ideal form of government.
 - But that is not a question we face in real life.

The real question we face is different :

Is democracy better than other forms of government that are there for us to choose from ?

Arguments for Democracy

- ▶ China's famine of 1958-1961 was the worst recorded famine in world history.
- ▶ Nearly three crore people died in this famine.
- ▶ During those days, India's economic condition was not much better than China.
- ▶ Yet India did not have a famine of the kind China had.
- ▶ Economists think that this was a result of different government policies in the two countries.

The existence of democracy in India made the Indian government respond to food scarcity in a way that the Chinese government did not.

- They point out that no large-scale famine has ever taken place in an independent and democratic country.
- If China too had multiparty elections, an opposition party and a press free to criticise the government, then so many people may not have died in the famine.

This example brings out one of the reasons why democracy is considered the best form of government.

Democracy
is better than any
other form of govt.
in responding to
the needs of the
people

A
non-democratic
government may and can
respond to the people's
needs, but it all depends
on the wishes of the
people who rule

①.

A democratic government is a better government because it is a more accountable form of government.

- There is another reason why democracy should lead to better decisions than any non-democratic government.
- Democracy is based on consultation and discussion.
- A democratic decision always involves many persons, discussions and meetings.
- When a number of people put their heads together, they are able to point out possible mistakes in any decision.
 - This takes time.
- But there is a big advantage in taking time over important decisions.
 - This reduces the chances of rash or irresponsible decisions.

②.

Thus democracy improves the quality of decision-making.

③.

Democracy provides a method to deal with difference and conflicts.

- In any society people are bound to have differences of opinions and interests.
- These differences are particularly sharp in a country like ours which has an amazing social diversity.
- People belong to different regions, speak different languages, practise different religions and have different castes.
- They look at the world very differently and have different preferences.
- The preferences of one group can clash with those of other groups.

HOW DO WE RESOLVE SUCH A CONFLICT ?

The conflict can be solved by brutal power :

Whichever group is more powerful will dictate its terms and others will have to accept that .

But that would lead to resentment and unhappiness.

Different groups may not be able to live together for long in such a way.

Democracy provides the only peaceful solution to this problem.

In democracy, no one is permanent winner .

No one is a permanent loser .

Different groups can live with one another peacefully.

In a diverse country like India, democracy keeps our country together .

- These three arguments were about the effects of democracy on the quality of government and social life.
- But the strongest the strongest argument for democracy is not about what democracy does to the government.
- It is about what democracy is not bring about better than other forms of government.

④

Democracy enhances the dignity of citizens.

- People are not subjects of a ruler, they are the rulers themselves .
- Even when they make mistakes , there are responsible for their conduct .

5.

Finally, democracy is better than other forms of government because it allows us to correct our own mistakes.

- As we saw above, there is no guarantee that mistakes cannot be made in democracy.
- No form of government can guarantee that.
- The advantage in a democracy is that such mistakes cannot be hidden for long.
- There is a space for public discussion on these mistakes.
 - And there is a room for correction.

Either the rulers have to change their decisions, or the rulers can be changed.

Summary

Democracy cannot get us everything and is not the solution to all problems.

But it is clearly better than any other alternative that we know.

- It offers better chances of a good decision.
- It is likely to respect people's own wishes.
- Allows different kinds of people to live together.
- Even when it fails to do some of these things, it allows a way of correcting its mistakes.
- Offers more dignity to all citizens.

That is why democracy is considered the best form of government.

* BROADER MEANINGS OF DEMOCRACY

- ▷ In this chapter we have considered the meaning of democracy in a limited and descriptive sense.
- ▷ We have understood democracy as a form of government.
- ▷ This way of defining democracy helps us to identify a clear set of minimal features that a democracy must have.
- ▷ The most common form that democracy takes in our times is that of a representative democracy.
- ▷ In the countries we call democracy, all the people do not rule.
- ▷ A majority is allowed to take decisions on behalf of all the people.
- The majority of people rule through their elected representatives.
- ◇ This becomes necessary because :
 - Modern democracies involve such a large number of people that it is physically impossible for them to sit together and take a collective decision.
 - Even if they could, the citizen does not have the time, the desire or the skills to take part in all the decisions.

This gives us a clear but minimal understanding of democracy.

This clarity helps us to distinguish democracies from non-democracies.

But it does not allow us to distinguish between a democracy and a good democracy.

It doesn't allow us to see the operation of democracy beyond government

For this we need to turn to broader meanings of democracy.

Those who are not powerful have the same say in taking the decision as those who are powerful.



This can apply to a government or a family or any other organization.

Thus democracy is also a principle that can be applied to any sphere of life.

✧ Ideal standard that all democracies must aim to become :

- "True democracy will come to this country only when no one goes hungry to bed."
- "In a democracy every citizen must be able to play equal role in decision making."
 - For this you don't need just an equal right to vote.
 - Every citizen needs to have equal information, basic education, equal resources and a lot of commitment."

If we take these ideals seriously, then no country in the world is a democracy.

Why we value democracy?

- It enables us to judge on existing democracy and identify its weaknesses.
- It helps us to distinguish between a minimal democracy and a good democracy.
- At this stage we just need to note that democracy can apply to many spheres of life and that democracy can take many forms.
- There can be various ways of taking decisions in a democratic manner, as long as the basic principle of consultation on an equal basis is accepted.

- ◇ The most common form of democracy in today's world is rule through people's elected representatives.
- ◇ But if the community is small, there can be other ways of taking democratic decisions.
- ◇ All the people can sit together and take decisions directly.
 - This is how Gram Sabha should work in a village.

* No Country is a Perfect Democracy

- The features of democracy that we discussed in this chapter provide only the minimum conditions of democracy.
- That does not make it an ideal democracy.
 - Every democracy has to try to realise the ideals of a democratic decision making.
- This cannot be achieved once and for all.
- This requires a constant effort to save and strengthen democratic forms of decision making.

What distinguished democracy from other government ?

- ▷ Other forms of government like monarchy, dictatorship or one-party rule do not require all citizens to take part in politics.
- ▷ In fact most non-democratic governments would like citizens not to take part in politics.

But democracy depends on active political participation by all citizens. That is why a study of democracy must focus on democratic politics.